

Unit 4 A Global Middle Ages, 1200–1500 CE

CHAPTER 14

Pax Mongolica: The Steppe Empire of the Mongols 579

Introduction	579
14.1 Song China and the Steppe Peoples	581
14.2 Chinggis Khan and the Early Mongol Empire	590
14.3 The Mongol Empire Fragments	598
14.4 Christianity and Islam outside Central Asia	605
Key Terms	615
Section Summary	615
Assessments	616

CHAPTER 15

States and Societies in Sub-Saharan Africa 621

Introduction	621
15.1 Culture and Society in Medieval Africa	623
15.2 Medieval Sub-Saharan Africa	634
15.3 The People of the Sahel	647
Key Terms	656
Section Summary	656
Assessments	657

CHAPTER 16

Climate Change and Plague in the Fourteenth Century 661

Introduction	661
16.1 Asia, North Africa, and Europe in the Early Fourteenth Century	662
16.2 Famine, Climate Change, and Migration	672
16.3 The Black Death from East to West	679
16.4 The Long-Term Effects of Global Transformation	687
Key Terms	692
Section Summary	692
Assessments	693

CHAPTER 17

The Ottomans, the Mamluks, and the Ming 697

Introduction	697
17.1 The Ottomans and the Mongols	699
17.2 From the Mamluks to Ming China	720
17.3 Gunpowder and Nomads in a Transitional Age	733
Key Terms	742
Section Summary	742
Assessments	743

Appendix A Glossary 747

Appendix B *World History*, Volume 1, to 1500: Maps and Timelines 753

Appendix C World Maps 757

Appendix D Recommended Resources for the Study of World History 763

Index 765

Preface

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About *World History*

World History is designed to support both semesters of the world history course offered at both two-year and four-year institutions. Serving a student base of both majors and non-majors in the field, as well as an institutional variation in requirements of one or two semesters depending on the plan of study, the course introduces students to a global perspective of history conveyed within an engaging narrative. Concepts and assessments are presented in ways to help students think critically about the issues they encounter so they can broaden their perspective of global history and how the topics studied apply to their current life as citizens of the world.

The text shows how historical content and the ways in which history is studied are relevant to modern-day needs and situations. The narrative shows readers the *why* of historical events and people, providing context and import to engage students. A primary goal of the book is to include content, scholarship, and activities that explore a variety of perspectives, including those traditionally underrepresented in this canon.

Being able to thoughtfully achieve a global approach requires explicit discussions about the challenge historians face in their work. Each instructor and student enters the classroom with a construct that informs their existing understanding as well as their ability to understand and to appreciate novel perspectives. *World History* works to present an honest and authentic view of history for students to explore. The authors and reviewers achieve balance by introducing and juxtaposing people's experiences of history for a rich and nuanced discussion. New resources and new voices are integrated into the text in a deep and meaningful manner. Primary source material represents the cultures being discussed from a firsthand perspective whenever possible, showing a variety of experiences and voices that stress the interconnected nature of people and societies throughout history. Moreover, the work of diverse and underrepresented scholars and scholarship bolsters the text's ability to embrace diversity of thought and interpretation while spotlighting parts of history and places that often receive less coverage in history textbooks. Students will be challenged to use empathy to understand others' ways of thinking in order to better understand, analyze, and evaluate today's changes in the world.

Pedagogical Foundation

Learning Objectives

Every module begins with a set of clear and concise learning objectives that have been designed to be both measurable and meaningful. These objectives closely align with current teaching practice and aim to help the instructor decide what content to include or assign, and to guide student expectations of learning. After completing the module and end-of-module exercises, students should be able to demonstrate mastery of the learning objectives.

Key Features

Various features throughout each chapter engage students with the content while having them practice some of the most essential skills in the study of history, such as the examination of primary sources, the analysis of multiple accounts of an event or period, the study of non-textual artifacts, and the exploration of how specific historical topics connect to today's world.

- **In Their Own Words:** Students are presented with a textual primary source for review and/or analysis, with discussion/reflection questions included. This feature bolsters the foundational importance of using primary sources in historical studies.
- **Dueling Voices:** Learners are given either a historiographical debate, or a side-by-side primary source reading that offers two different interpretations of the same event. Sometimes these are directly contrasting, and sometimes they help elucidate different perspectives. Discussion questions are included. This feature highlights that history is an interpretive discipline and that historians must regularly grapple with conflicting and at times contradictory information and approaches.
- **Beyond the Book:** Non-textual sources—such as art, physical objects, or architecture—are presented for study with the goal of helping students understand the value of these kinds of sources in historical work. Discussion questions open up conversations about how to understand these important artifacts.
- **The Past Meets the Present:** Students explore how an aspect of chapter content speaks to an issue in the present day, and have the opportunity to engage further in the topic with reflection/discussion questions.
- **Link to Learning:** This feature provides a very brief introduction to online resources—videos, interactives, collections, maps, and other engaging resources—that are pertinent to students' exploration of the topic at hand.

Section Summaries

Section summaries distill the information in each section for both students and instructors down to key, concise points addressed in the section.

Key Terms

Key terms are bold and are followed by a definition in context. Definitions of key terms are also listed in each end-of-chapter Glossary, as well as a book-level Glossary appendix.

Assessments

A variety of assessments allow instructors to confirm core conceptual understanding, elicit brief explanations that demonstrate student understanding, and offer more in-depth assignments that enable learners to dive more deeply into a topic or history-study skill.

- **Review Questions** test for conceptual apprehension of key concepts.
- **Check Your Understanding Questions** require students to explain concepts in words.
- **Application and Reflection Questions** dive deeply into the material to support longer reflection, group discussion, or written assignments.

Answers to Questions in the Book

The end-of-chapter Review, Check Your Understanding, and Reflection Questions are intended for homework assignments or classroom discussion; thus, student-facing answers are not provided in the book. Answers and sample answers are provided in the Instructor Answer Guide, for instructors to share with students at their discretion, as is standard for such resources.

About the Authors

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